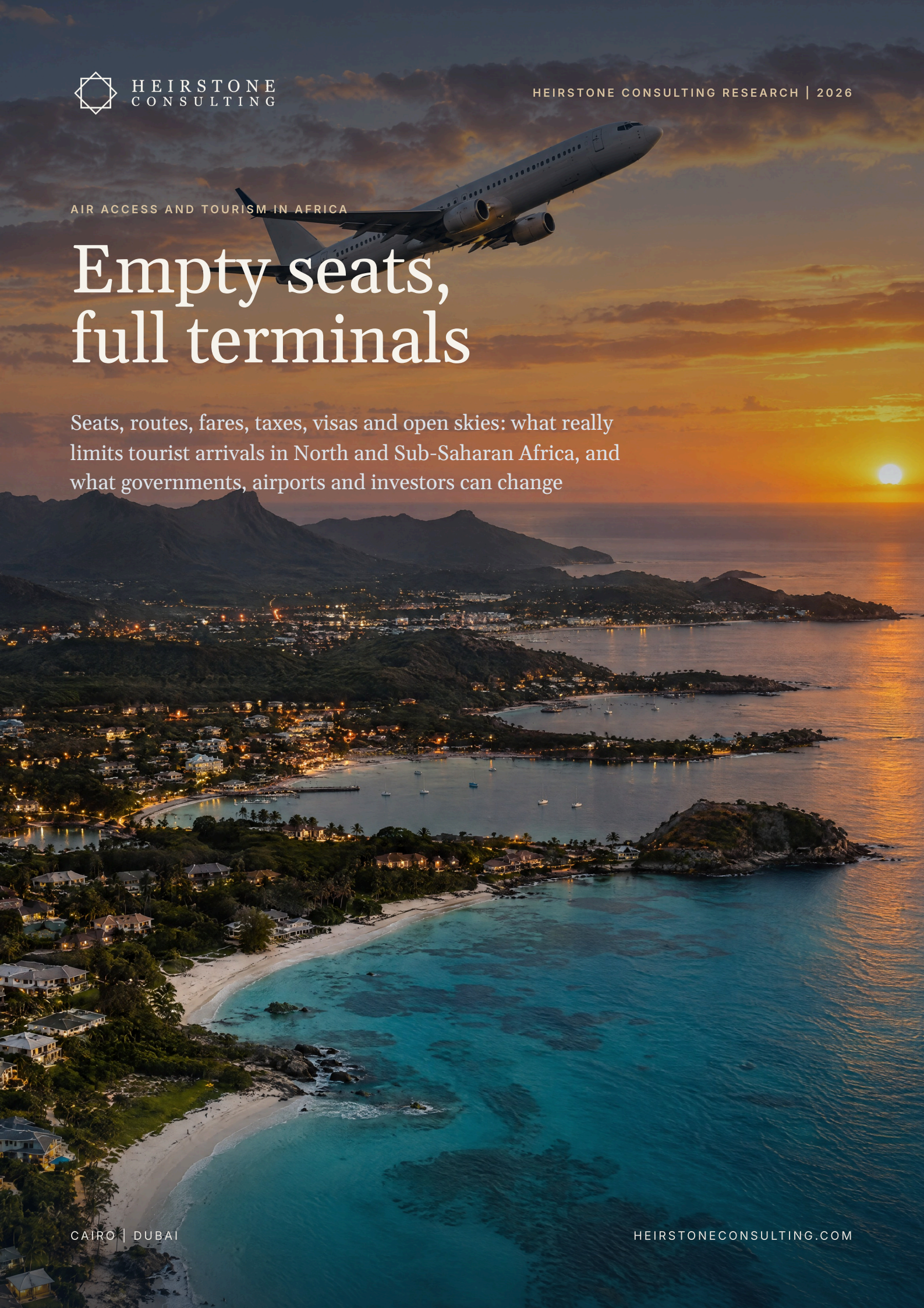
HEIRSTONE CONSULTING

AIR ACCESS AND TOURISM IN AFRICA

Empty seats, full terminals

Seats, routes, fares, taxes, visas and open skies: what really limits tourist arrivals in North and Sub-Saharan Africa, and what governments, airports and investors can change



THE REPORT IN SIX NUMBERS

32.3% passenger growth at Sharm el-Sheikh in 2025, the fastest of Africa's 26 largest airports

75.3% Africa's 2025 passenger load factor, the lowest of any world region (world: 83.6%)

113% Marrakech airport traffic in 2025 as a share of the design capacity of its terminals

US$68 average taxes and charges on an international departure from Africa in 2024, against US$34 in the Middle East and US$30 in Europe

8 of 38 signatories of the Single African Air Transport Market that had put its concrete measures in place by 2025

+80% growth in Cape Town's international passengers over ten years of its route-development programme

CONTENTS

	Summary	3
1	Flown by others	4
2	The pinch points	6
3	What moved arrivals	10
4	Tariffs on arrivals	15
5	The Heirstone Air Access Scorecard	20
6	North Africa and Sub-Saharan Africa	23
7	What to do	26
	Notes, sources and definitions	27

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is written for tourism authorities, airports, airlines, governments, hotel investors, developers and development finance institutions working in North and Sub-Saharan Africa. It draws on public sources current in 2026: IATA, AFRAA, OAG, UN Tourism, the African Development Bank and African Union, national statistics offices, airport operators, airline reports and the press. Every figure is referenced in the exhibit sources and in the notes.

Figures we derive from published inputs, such as the share of seats filled, arrivals per airport passenger or capital cost per unit of terminal capacity, are labelled Heirstone analysis and show their inputs.

No public series gives annual international seats by African country. Where seats are not published we use airport passengers, airline passengers or flight frequencies instead, and say so each time.

SUMMARY

One seat in four flew empty in Africa in 2025, yet the busiest leisure gateways ran full

Most debate on African air access asks for more flights and stronger national airlines. The evidence points elsewhere. Seats are plentiful on average and scarce at a handful of leisure gateways, and governments set much of their price through taxes, visas and traffic rights. Tourism strategy should start with those levers.

1 **Foreign airlines hold just over half of Africa's international seats.**

Africa took about 5.3% of the world's international tourist arrivals in 2025, while its airlines flew 2.2% of world passenger kilometres. Non-African carriers held 52.8% of Africa's international seats in August 2026, according to AFRAA.

2 **On average, seats are plentiful.**

Africa's 2025 load factor of 75.3% was the lowest of any region, according to IATA. In each 2026 period we could source, capacity grew faster than traffic: 6.8% against 4.1% in the first quarter, 8.3% against 6.7% in August.

3 **The squeeze is at a few leisure gateways.**

On our estimate Cape Town's 2025 international passengers equalled about 87% of its published seats. Marrakech's traffic reached 113% of its terminals' design capacity in 2025. Nine leisure gateways, led by Sharm el-Sheikh at 32.3%, grew 15.4% in 2025, about twice the hubs' rate.

4 **Governments set much of the fare.**

International departure charges run from US$15 to 29 in Tunisia, Morocco and South Africa to US$112 to 180 in Ghana, Senegal and Nigeria. AFRAA puts taxes and charges at 35 to 40% of African ticket prices. The 2024 average departure charge, US$68, was 52 times African airlines' 2025 net profit per passenger.

5 **Open skies are signed more often than practised.**

Thirty-eight states have signed the Single African Air Transport Market commitment; AFRAA counts eight that had applied its measures by 2025. The share of intra-African travel scenarios needing a visa before travel rose to 51.1% in 2025, and US$857m of airline revenue was blocked in seven African jurisdictions in October 2025.

6 **Bought seats have outperformed owned airlines.**

Egypt paid tour operators US$30 a seat in 2016 and reached a record of about 19m arrivals in 2025. Cape Town's route-development partnership added 33 international routes in ten years. Morocco's arrivals rose from 12.9m to 19.8m between 2019 and 2025, and Ryanair opened its fifth base there in 2026. Tunisia's arrivals grew while Tunisair lost a third of its passengers.

WHAT IT MEANS

Tourism authorities should fund route development and report arrivals per inbound seat at each gateway, rather than the national airline's size.

Finance ministries should price departures against the US$30 to 34 charged in Europe and the Middle East.

Airports should add terminal space first where leisure traffic already exceeds design.

Developers and hotel investors should test seats, price, entry rules and terminal headroom before they buy land.

7

dated cases in the Heirstone Air Access Case Book, from five countries

20

countries rated on five levers in the Heirstone Air Access Scorecard



CHAPTER 1

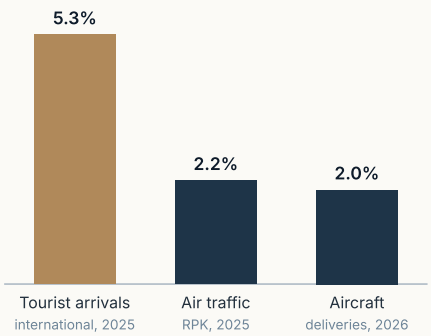
01

Flown by others

EXHIBIT 1

Africa's share of world tourist arrivals is more than twice its airlines' share of world air traffic

Africa's share of the world total, %; the three measures differ



Source: UN Tourism via AFRAA Blocked Funds paper (2026), which gives the 81.3m arrivals and the 5.3% share; IATA (29 Jan 2026); AFRAA (Sep 2026).

Africa received 81.3 million international tourist arrivals in 2025, according to UN Tourism figures cited by AFRAA, about 5.3% of the world total. African airlines carried 2.2% of the world's passenger traffic in the same year, measured by IATA in revenue passenger kilometres, and the share was the same in August 2026.

Part of the gap is measurement. Passenger kilometres weight each trip by distance, arrivals include visitors who come overland, and IATA counts traffic by the airline's country of registration, so a holidaymaker flying Ryanair to Marrakech adds to Europe's share. In August 2026 non-African carriers held 52.8% of all international seats to and from Africa, according to AFRAA.

For a tourism ministry the useful question is how many seats reach its gateways, at a price and time that travellers will buy, whoever flies them. A large national airline can coexist with modest tourism, and a shrinking one with a boom, as Chapter 3 shows.

This chapter sets out the continental picture: who flies Africa's international passengers and how full the aircraft are. Its main finding runs against the usual complaint. On average, Africa has more seats than it fills.

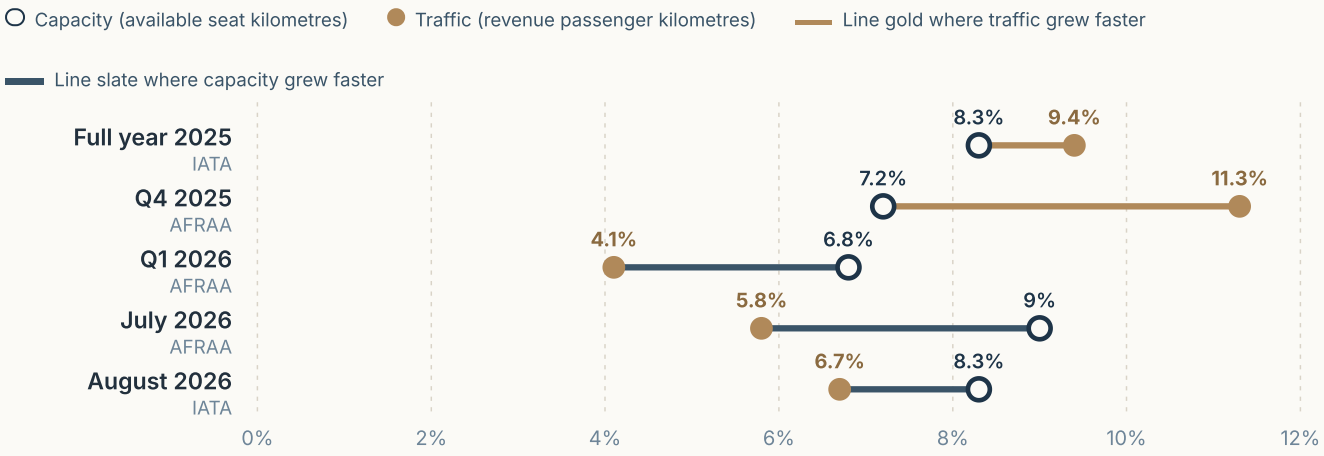
SEATS AND DEMAND

African airlines filled 75.3% of their seats in 2025, then added capacity faster than traffic in the 2026 months we could source

EXHIBIT 2

In the first quarter, July and August of 2026, African airlines added capacity faster than traffic

Year-on-year growth in African airlines' capacity and traffic, %

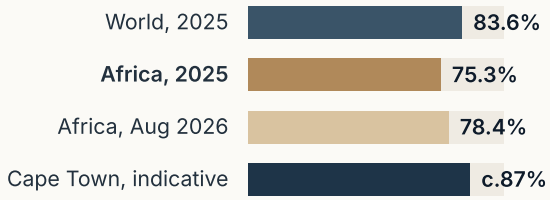


Source: IATA (29 Jan 2026; 30 Sep 2026); AFRAA Air Transport Reports Q4 2025 (May 2026) and Q1 2026 (Aug 2026); AFRAA performance update (15 Sep 2026). July figures as rounded by AFRAA. April to June 2026 not covered by the sources we used.

EXHIBIT 3

Africa's load factor is the lowest of any region; Cape Town's international seats appear to fill above the world average

Passenger load factor, %. Cape Town: two-way international passengers over two-way international seats, an indicative measure



Source: IATA (29 Jan 2026; 30 Sep 2026); Wesgro (Sep 2025; Jan 2026). **Heirstone analysis** for Cape Town: 3.3m passengers in 2025 on the 3.8m seats Wesgro reported in Sep 2025, period not stated.

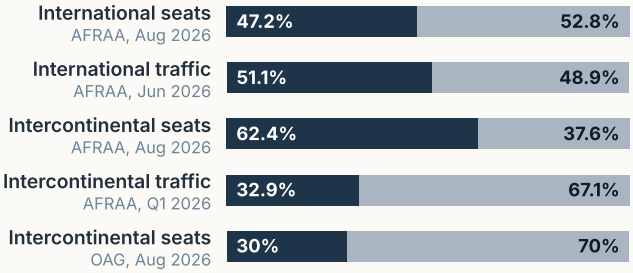
IATA put Africa's 2025 load factor at 75.3%, more than eight points below the world's record 83.6%: roughly one seat in four on African airlines flew empty. Traffic did outgrow capacity in 2025, by 9.4% against 8.3%. In the first quarter of 2026, and again in July and August, the pattern reversed; passenger revenue fell 1% in the first quarter.

The average hides the peaks: a resort gateway in high season can be full while the continental figure is not. On our indicative estimate, Cape Town's 2025 international passengers equalled about 87% of its published seats.

EXHIBIT 4

Who flies Africa's intercontinental passengers depends on whose figures you use

Share of capacity or traffic to and from Africa, African carriers (navy) and non-African carriers, %



Source: AFRAA performance update (15 Sep 2026); AFRAA Liberalization page, Q1 2026 analysis; OAG webinar (6 Aug 2026). AFRAA's intercontinental figures conflict and are shown as published.

Airlines are adding seats faster than passengers arrive to fill them. Seat capacity across Africa rose 8.8% in August 2026, and intra-African seats 10.5%. On these continental figures, most tourism boards need to fill seats that already exist more than they need new ones.

Direction matters as much as ownership. In the first quarter of 2026, 47% of African airlines' international traffic flew to or from Europe, 24% stayed within Africa, 19% went to the Middle East, 6% to Asia and 4% to the Americas.

CHAPTER 2



02

The pinch points

A leisure gateway runs out of seats, stands and terminal space on its busiest days long before national averages show any shortage.

c.87%

Cape Town's 2025 international passengers against its published two-way international seats (Heirstone analysis, indicative)

113%

Marrakech airport's 2025 traffic against the design capacity of its terminals, 9 million passengers a year since the 2016 extension

If the average seat is easy to find, the scarce seat is the one into a popular leisure gateway at the right time of year. Cape Town shows it most clearly. Its airport handled 3.3 million two-way international passengers in 2025, and Wesgro put its two-way international seat capacity at 3.8 million. On our calculation that is about 87% of seats filled, above the world's average load factor and far above Africa's, although Wesgro does not state the period of the seat count.

Marrakech handled 10.2 million passengers in 2025, 10.1% more than a year earlier, through terminals designed for 9 million in total since their extension in 2016. Zanzibar handled 2.69 million in 2025, up 13.9%, and its airport authority expects to finish a second terminal, for 1.4 million passengers a year, in 2026. At gateways like these the next seat is hard to add, because the terminal, the slot or the stand is already in use at the peak.

The leisure gateways are also where growth is fastest. Hurghada, a Red Sea resort airport, handled 11.4 million passengers in 2025, about 27% more than Nairobi. Sharm el-Sheikh grew 32.3%, the fastest of Africa's 26 largest airports, and Egypt's three Red Sea airports handled 23.3 million passengers between them.

Most new airport money, meanwhile, is going to hubs and capitals. This chapter maps where Africa flies, where the terminals are full and where the capital is being spent.

WHERE AFRICA FLIES

Four resort gateways now sit among Africa's ten busiest airports, next to the continental hubs

EXHIBIT 5

Hurghada, Cape Town and Marrakech each handle more passengers than Nairobi

24 of Africa's 26 busiest airports by passengers, 2025 (Entebbe and Oran not shown); airport role is Heirstone classification



Source: France Aviation Civile Services, Air Transport Data Trend Bulletin (2026), provisional 2025 figures; Réunion (France) not counted. Coordinates from FlightConnections for hub airports; other positions approximate. **Heirstone analysis.**

Nine of the 24 airports mapped are leisure gateways on our classification. Egypt's Red Sea airports and Morocco's five main airports together handled 53 million passengers in 2025. South of the Sahara only Cape Town and Zanzibar make the list, and traffic runs mainly through Johannesburg, Addis Ababa, Nairobi and Lagos.

Published seat counts agree: in December 2025 Marrakech ranked sixth in Africa with 588,000 departing seats, up 13.6%, and Hurghada tenth with 469,000, according to OAG data cited by ATTA. Cairo led Africa with 1.69 million, and only Johannesburg and Addis Ababa also offered more than a million.

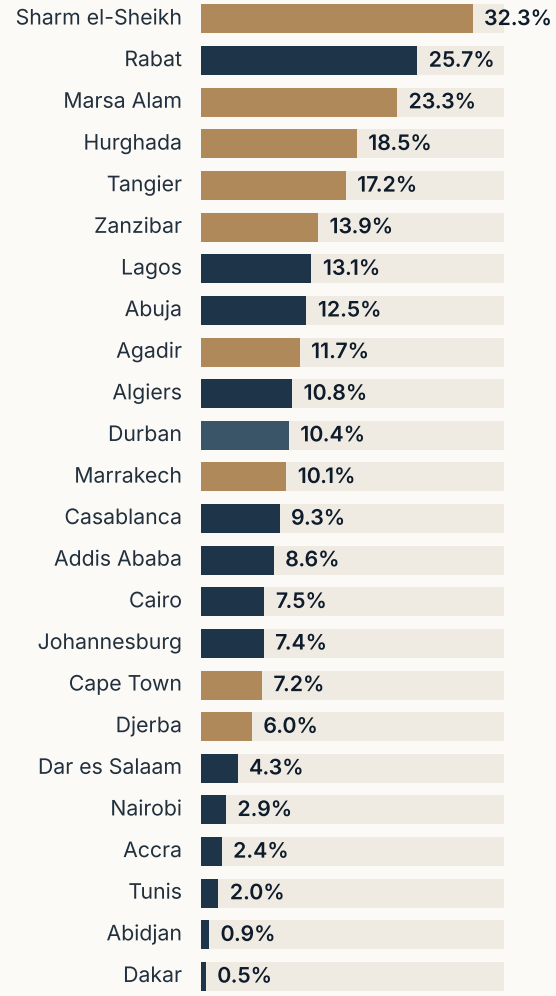
GROWTH AND HEADROOM

Traffic at leisure gateways grew about twice as fast as at the hubs in 2025

EXHIBIT 6

Leisure gateways led Africa's airport growth in 2025

Passenger growth in 2025 over 2024, %; gold = leisure gateway, navy = hub or capital, slate = mainly domestic

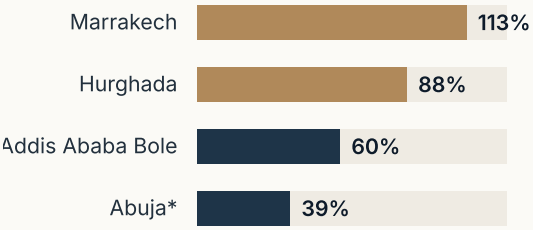


Source: France Aviation Civile Services, Air Transport Data Trend Bulletin (2026), provisional 2025 figures. **Heirstone analysis:** nine leisure gateways 56.0m passengers, +15.4%; fourteen hub and capital airports 129.6m, +7.6%. Entebbe (+10.1%) and Oran (+11.0%) not shown.

EXHIBIT 7

Marrakech is over design capacity; the hub terminals at Addis Ababa and Abuja have room

2025 airport passengers as % of the design capacity of the terminal(s) named



Source: Capacity: Bladi.net (Marrakech, 2016); Al Arabiya citing Ahram Online (Hurghada, 2014); Quartz (Addis Ababa, 2019); Vanguard citing FAAN (Abuja, 2018). Passengers: France Aviation Civile Services (2026). **Heirstone analysis.**
* Whole-airport traffic against the new terminal's capacity, which overstates use if older terminals remain open.

On our classification, the nine leisure gateways among the 24 airports mapped handled 56.0 million passengers in 2025, up 15.4%. The fourteen hub and capital-city airports handled 129.6 million, up 7.6%; adding Entebbe and Oran would leave that at 7.7%. The leisure group, with less than half the hubs' traffic, added 7.5 million passengers against their 9.1 million.

The pressure is uneven. Marrakech passed the design capacity of its terminals in 2024 and reached 113% of it in 2025. Bole in Addis Ababa, expanded in 2019, used about 60% of its 22 million capacity in 2025, and Abuja about 39% of its new terminal's 15 million. Hurghada, expanded in 2014 to handle 13 million passengers a year, was 88% full in 2025.

The planning consequence is direct. At Marrakech, new routes and marketing will meet terminal limits at peak times until capacity is added; Zanzibar, where traffic grew 13.9% in 2025, is adding a second terminal. At Addis Ababa and Abuja the terminals can take far more traffic than they now receive, and the binding constraints lie elsewhere: in visas, prices and what the destination offers.

WHERE THE AIRPORT MONEY GOES

Four hub and capital-city projects account for about 112 million passengers a year of new design capacity

EXHIBIT 8

Capital cost per unit of capacity ranges from about US$90m to US$290m per million passengers

Selected airport projects: design capacity, cost and status as published

AIRPORT PROJECT	COUNTRY	DESIGN CAPACITY (M PAX A YEAR)	COST AS PUBLISHED	US$ EQUIVALENT	US$M PER M PAX OF CAPACITY	STATUS AND OPERATOR OR FINANCIER
HUBS AND CAPITALS						
Bishoftu International (new)	Ethiopia	60 (phase 1), 110	US$10bn	10.0bn	91 to 167	Phase 1 due 2029; Ethiopian Airlines Group; AfDB up to US$500m
Cairo International, Terminal 4	Egypt	30 to 40	US$4.5bn (2026 estimate)	4.5bn	113 to 150	Planned; opening expected within four years (2026)
Luanda Dr António Agostinho Neto (new)	Angola	15	n/p	n/p	n/c	Opened Nov 2023; built by Chinese contractors
Bugesera International (new)	Rwanda	7 (phase 1), 14 (2032)	US$2bn (2023 estimate; US$0.8bn in the original plan, for 4.5m)	2.0bn	143 to 286	Works paused 2019 for redesign; due 2028; Qatar Airways 60%
Nairobi JKIA, renovation and new terminal	Kenya	c.22 (target)	KES 154.2bn	c.1.19bn	n/c	Contract signed Jun 2026; China Road and Bridge Corporation
Dakar Blaise Diagne (new)	Senegal	n/p	EUR 566m (2011 budget)	n/c	n/c	Opened Dec 2017; AIBD SA
LEISURE GATEWAYS						
Hurghada, expanded airport	Egypt	13	n/p	n/p	n/c	88% used in 2025 (Heirstone analysis)
Marrakech Menara, existing terminals	Morocco	9	n/p	n/p	n/c	113% used in 2025 (Heirstone analysis); extended 2016

Source: AfDB (2025); Egypt Today (2025) and Ahram Online via Travel News (2026); China Daily (2023); Al Jazeera (2019), CNN (2023) and The New Times (2019, 2024); The Star and Daily Nation citing KAA (2026); APS via Seneweb (2011) and AIBD SA; Al Arabiya (2014); Bladi.net (2016). US$ equivalent: KES at 129.3 per US$ (World Bank, 2025 average). n/p: not published in the sources we could verify; n/c: not computed. **Heirstone analysis.**

The first phase of Bishoftu, Cairo's Terminal 4, Luanda's new airport and the first phase of Bugesera add up to about 112 million passengers a year of design capacity, roughly 12 times what Nairobi's JKIA handled in 2025. The African Union announced a US$30bn plan for aviation infrastructure in October 2025, and AFRAA puts the need at US$25bn to 30bn over the next decade.

The cost of capacity varies by a factor of more than three across these projects, and timing slips. Bugesera's budget rose from US$0.8bn in the original plan, for an airport of 4.5 million passengers, to US$2bn in 2023 after a redesign for 7 million in its first phase; works were paused in 2019 for that redesign, and opening is now expected in 2028. Investors whose hotel or resort depends on a new airport should treat its published opening date as a best case.

US$30bn

African Union plan for aviation infrastructure under SAATM, announced October 2025

2.4x

rise in Bugesera's budget between the original plan and 2023, with a larger design; opening now expected in 2028



CHAPTER 3

03

What moved arrivals

Seven dated cases from five countries show what happened to tourist arrivals when seats were added, priced differently or taken away.

No public series gives annual international seats by African country, so each case uses the best available proxy: airport passengers, airline passengers or flight frequencies. We call the set the Heirstone Air Access Case Book. It covers low-cost bases, a route-development programme, charter incentives, flight suspensions and the closure of a national airline between 2015 and 2026.

Read together, the cases suggest that where seats were the binding constraint, adding them moved arrivals: in Morocco as low-cost bases spread, in Cape Town after 2015, and in Egypt after 2016, where seat incentives and charter airlines rebuilt arrivals from 5.4 million to 13.0 million by 2019, on the way to a record of about 19 million in 2025. Where a large source market stops flying, arrivals can fall faster than other markets replace its seats, so a spread of source markets and a ready incentive budget both matter.

The national airline was rarely the channel: arrivals rose in Tunisia while Tunisair lost a third of its passengers.

The ratios we show between arrivals and capacity are indicative. The measures differ from case to case, periods do not always match, and the counts include residents, transit passengers and diaspora visitors. We state the measure each time.

> *Where seats were the binding constraint, adding them moved arrivals. The national airline was rarely the channel.*

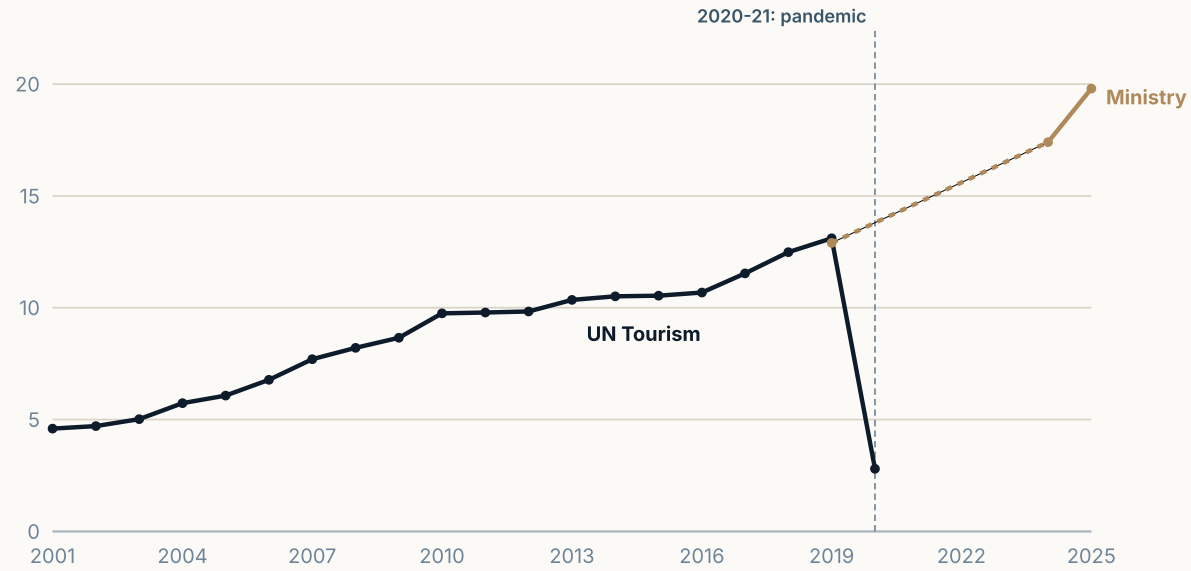
CASE: MOROCCO

Morocco's arrivals more than doubled between 2004 and 2019, and reached 19.8 million in 2025 as low-cost bases spread

EXHIBIT 9

Arrivals rose from 5.7 million in 2004 to 13.1 million in 2019, and to 19.8 million in 2025 on the ministry's count

International arrivals, millions, 2001 to 2025. Navy: UN Tourism data to 2020; gold: Ministry of Tourism border arrivals, including Moroccans resident abroad (dashed line joins 2019 and 2024)



Source: World Bank, World Development Indicators, ST.INT.ARVL (UN Tourism data); Ministry of Tourism via Hespress (2023), MAP (2025) and Daba Finance (2026).

Morocco's arrivals more than doubled in fifteen years on UN Tourism data, from 5.7 million in 2004 to 9.8 million in 2010 and 13.1 million in 2019. After the pandemic they passed the ministry's 2019 record of 12.9 million, reaching 17.4 million in 2024 and 19.8 million in 2025.

The recent growth has come with low-cost bases. Ryanair opened its fifth Moroccan base, at Rabat, in 2026, with two aircraft and 20 routes, and says its aircraft investment in Morocco exceeds US$1.6bn; Air Arabia Maroc flies to 16 destinations from Casablanca.

Rabat's traffic grew 25.7% in 2025, to 2.17 million, and Tangier's 17.2%. Marrakech handled 10.2 million passengers in 2025, more than the 9 million a year its terminals were designed for after the 2016 extension.

Two cautions apply. Almost half (49%) of Morocco's 2024 arrivals were Moroccans resident abroad, so arrivals overstate foreign tourism. And airport counts include both directions and residents. Between 2024 and 2025, arrivals rose 13.8% and passengers at the five main airports 11.6% (Heirstone analysis).

+25.7%

Rabat airport traffic in 2025, the second-fastest growth among Africa's 26 largest airports

5th

Ryanair base in Morocco, opened at Rabat in 2026 with 20 routes

26m

Morocco's target for annual tourists by 2030, against 19.8m in 2025

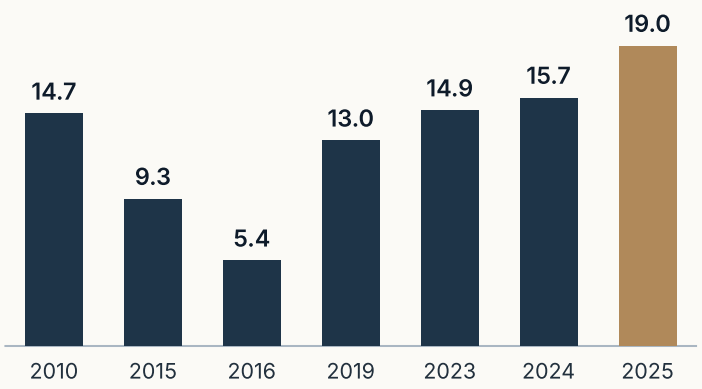
CASE: EGYPT

After two source markets suspended flights, Egypt rebuilt its arrivals on charter seats and incentives, to a record of about 19 million in 2025

EXHIBIT 10

Arrivals rose from 5.4m in 2016 to 13.0m in 2019 and a record of about 19m in 2025

International arrivals, millions, selected years



Source: World Bank WDI (UN Tourism data), 2010 to 2019; the Minister of Tourism via Egypt Today (2024) and Economy Middle East, 2023 and 2024, and via Egypt Independent (2026), 2025, a rounded estimate.

TIMELINE

4 Nov 2015	UK suspends flights to Sharm el-Sheikh
6 Nov 2015	Russia cancels all flights to Egypt, after the Metrojet Flight 9268 crash
Mar 2016	US$30 a seat paid to tour operators on flights 60 to 90% full; low-cost airline incentives planned
Apr 2018	Moscow-Cairo flights resume
22 Oct 2019	UK lifts the Sharm el-Sheikh suspension
Aug 2021	Russian flights to Hurghada and Sharm el-Sheikh resume
Sep 2022	Cabinet plans leased aircraft for lower-fare flights to Red Sea resorts

Sources: UK Government (2015, 2019); The National (2015); Associated Press and Egypt Today (2021); Egypt Independent (2016, 2022).

Arrivals fell from 9.3 million in 2015 to 5.4 million in 2016 after the British and Russian decisions. The UK lifted its suspension in October 2019, and Russian flights to the Red Sea resorts resumed in August 2021.

Recovery did not wait for those markets. By March 2016 the Ministry of Tourism was paying tour operators US$30 a seat on flights 60 to 90% full, and planned incentives for low-cost airlines. Arrivals reached 13.0 million in 2019, before Russian flights returned to the Red Sea, and about 19 million in 2025, when second-half tourism revenue rose 17.3% to about US$10.2bn (Central Bank of Egypt). Arrivals rose 43.5% in the first quarter of 2026, to about 5.6 million, which the tourism minister attributed in part to Egypt keeping its airspace open while several regional airlines operated from Egyptian airports.

Egypt's resort coast is served mainly by charter and leisure airlines, and Air Cairo, which calls itself Egypt's national hybrid airline, is building Hurghada into a key hub of its network. The model filled the Red Sea quickly and, with seat incentives, refilled it after 2016. Its exposure is to concentration: when two large markets suspended flights in 2015, other markets took more than a year to replace their seats.

Seat incentives cost little next to infrastructure and complement it. At US$30 a seat, a programme covering one million seats costs US$30m, under 1% of the US$4.5bn estimate for Cairo's Terminal 4, designed for 30 million passengers a year or more (Heirstone illustration). They can also be aimed at markets that do not yet send many visitors.

c.19m

Egypt's international arrivals in 2025, a record, up from 5.4m in 2016

US$30

per seat paid to tour operators on flights 60 to 90% full (2016)

15 days

visa-free stay at Red Sea resorts for EU, UK and US citizens

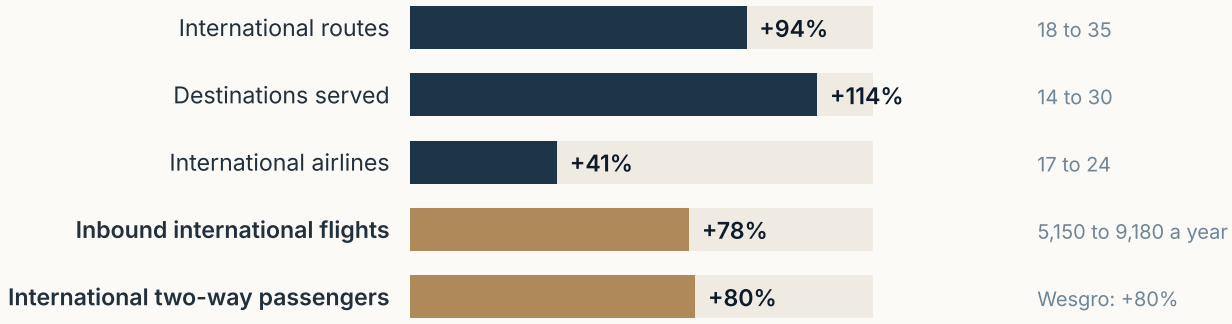
CASE: CAPE TOWN

A route-development unit brought Cape Town 33 new international routes in ten years

EXHIBIT 11

Ten years of Cape Town Air Access: flights up 78%, international passengers up 80%

Change between 2015 and 2025, %



Source: Wesgro, Cape Town Air Access celebrates 10 years (22 Sep 2025) and brochure (Feb 2026). **Heirstone analysis** of growth rates from the published counts.

Cape Town Air Access began in 2015 as a partnership between Wesgro, the Western Cape Government, the City of Cape Town, South African Tourism, Cape Town Tourism, Airports Company South Africa and private partners. It works airline by airline: it builds the business case for a route, then supports it with destination marketing. It has secured 33 new international routes, 11 of them to African destinations, and by 2025 24 international airlines linked Cape Town to 30 destinations.

The programme reports its own results, without a counterfactual, but they are consistent with each other. Inbound international flights rose 78% and international passengers 80%, about one passenger of growth for each unit of frequency growth. The airport handled a record 11.1 million passengers in 2025, 3.3 million of them international, and seat capacity for the 2025/26 winter was set 38% above 2019. In July 2026 LATAM began three weekly flights from São Paulo, a route on which more than 42,000 passengers had flown with South African Airways in 2025.

Wesgro estimates that every 100 international passengers support about two jobs in the Western Cape. Applied to about 1.65 million inbound international passengers in 2025, that is roughly 33,000 jobs. The Western Cape received about 1.45 million international visitors in 2024, about 0.76 for every inbound international seat in Wesgro's published count (Heirstone analysis; periods differ). Any gateway that publishes its seat count could report the same ratio.

33

new international routes since 2015, 11 of them to African destinations

0.76

Western Cape international visitors per inbound international seat (2024 visitors; seats as published Sep 2025)

6

public bodies fund the programme, with private partners

AIRLINES AND ARRIVALS

Where national airlines shrank or stalled, arrivals often kept growing

EXHIBIT 12

Arrivals against capacity: the ratio depends on the measure, and the national airline is a weak guide

Change in arrivals against change in a capacity measure, by case. Ratio = arrivals % change divided by measure % change; n/m = not meaningful

CASE	PERIOD	ARRIVALS*	CAPACITY MEASURE	CHANGE	GOLD ARRIVALS, NAVY CAPACITY	RATIO
Cape Town	2015-2025	+80.0%	Inbound international flights (arrivals measure: international passengers)	+78.3%		1.02
Morocco	2024-2025	+13.8%	Passengers at Casablanca, Marrakech, Agadir, Tangier and Rabat	+11.6%		1.19
Egypt	2016-2019	+141.3%	US$30 a seat paid to tour operators in 2016, before Russian flights returned to the Red Sea	n/a		n/m
Tunisia	2019-2024	+9.0%	Tunisair passengers 2018-2025	-34.7%		n/m
Namibia	2019-2023	-45.9%	Air Namibia closed Feb 2021; pandemic in period	n/a		n/m

Source: Heirstone Air Access Case Book, from Wesgro; France Aviation Civile Services; Ministry of Tourism (Morocco) via MAP and Daba Finance; World Bank WDI (UN Tourism data); Kapitalis (2025); African Manager (2019); Ecofin Agency (2026); Ministry of Environment, Forestry and Tourism (Namibia), Tourist Statistical Report 2023. **Heirstone analysis.** Measures and periods differ by case; ratios are indicative, not causal. * International visitor arrivals, except Cape Town (international two-way airport passengers); Morocco includes Moroccans resident abroad; Egypt's period starts from its 2016 low.

Kenya's international arrivals rose 34.8% between 2013 and 2019 on UN Tourism data. Kenya's Tourism Research Institute credited part of 2024's growth to new scheduled airlines and the return of Brussels Airlines.

Seychelles received 398,841 visitors in 2025, 13.7% more than in 2023, on the National Bureau of Statistics count. Arrivals to the end of September 2026 were 7.2% below a year earlier; the statistics office gives no cause.

Mauritius grew about 46% from 2011 to 2018 on UN Tourism data, then stalled: 2025 arrivals were 2.6% above 2018 on the Statistics Mauritius count, and air arrivals rose 0.2% in the first half of 2026. India, up 33.5% in 2025, is the one large market growing quickly.

Namibia closed Air Namibia in February 2021 after N$8.4bn of state support over ten years; 2023 arrivals were 46% below 2019, a comparison the pandemic distorts.

> *Buy seats before buying airlines.*

-35%

Tunisair passengers, 2018-2025, while Tunisia's arrivals rose

-46%

Namibia's 2023 arrivals against 2019, two years after Air Namibia closed

CHAPTER 4

04 Tariffs on arrivals

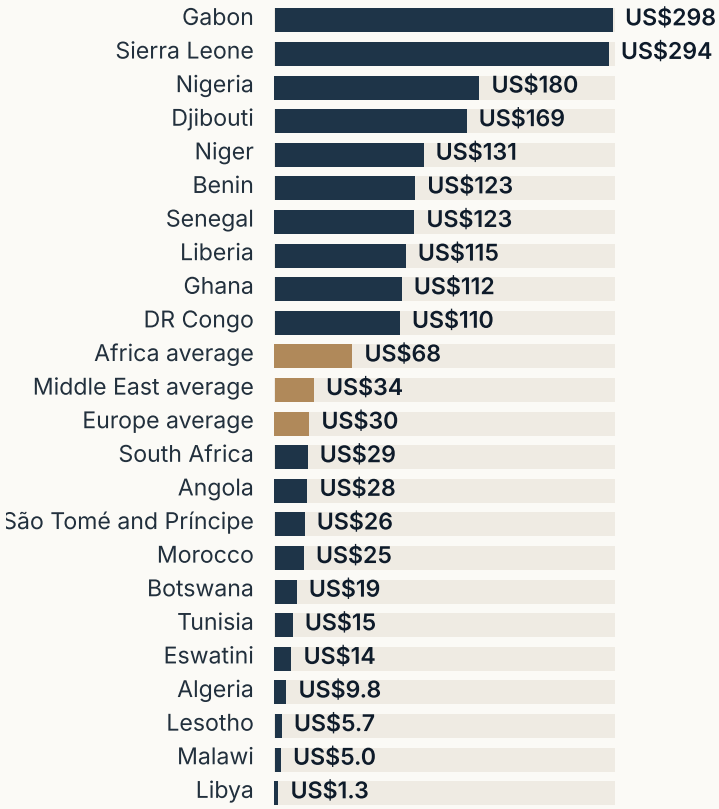
Ticket taxes, visas, closed traffic rights and blocked airline funds are choices made by governments. Together they set much of the price and the ease of reaching an African destination, and they fall hardest on the regional and short-haul travellers that tourism plans say they want.

This chapter takes the four in turn: what the state adds to a ticket, how far open skies have gone, who needs a visa and how much airline cash is stuck.

EXHIBIT 13

International departure charges range from US$1 in Libya to US$298 in Gabon

Taxes, fees and charges per departing international passenger, US$, September 2024; AFRAA's ten highest and ten lowest, plus South Africa, with averages in gold



Source: AFRAA, Taxes, Fees and Charges Study 2024 (published June 2025), IATA ACIC data. South Africa, eleventh lowest, from AFRAA's table.

AFRAA's 2024 survey puts the average of taxes, fees and charges on an international departure from Africa at US$68, twice the Middle East's US$34 and 2.3 times Europe's US$30. The range is wide: Libya charges US$1.30 and Algeria US$9.80, while Gabon charges US$297.70 and Sierra Leone US$294.

The spread follows geography. West Africa averages US$109 per international departure and Central Africa US$107; North Africa averages US$25. Several of the continent's largest destinations sit at the low end: Tunisia at US$15, Morocco at US$25 and South Africa at US$29. Nigeria's US$180 is 11.7 times Tunisia's.

AFRAA puts taxes and charges at 35 to 40% of African ticket prices, against about 20% globally, and at more than 55% of the cheapest base fares. An average African ticket carries 3.5 separate taxes, against 2.53 in Europe.

6 of 10

of the highest international departure charges are levied in French-speaking states

THE STATE'S SHARE

On AFRAA's 2024 averages, a one-stop trip within Africa carries about US$128 in taxes and charges each way

EXHIBIT 14

Taxes and charges on an illustrative one-stop journey dwarf African airlines' net profit per passenger

US$ per passenger: AFRAA 2024 continental averages for regional departure, transfer and arrival charges, against airline net profit per passenger in 2025



Source: AFRAA, Taxes, Fees and Charges Study 2024; AFRAA Blocked Funds paper (May 2026) citing IATA. **Heirstone analysis:** sum of averages for an illustrative journey; individual journeys vary.

Charges stack up along a journey. AFRAA's 2024 averages are US$59.05 to depart on a regional flight, US$34.10 to arrive and, in the 42 countries that levy one, US$34.40 to change aircraft. On those averages, a one-stop journey between two African cities carries about US$128 in taxes and charges each way. Arrival taxes alone rose from US$14.10 in 2021 to US$34.10 in 2024, and seven more countries began taxing transfers between 2022 and 2024.

On short routes the charges can exceed the fare. In AFRAA's anonymised examples, taxes reached 292% of the base fare on one short intra-African route, 74% of the ticket price. OAG cites taxes of more than US$400 on a two-hour flight from Accra to Freetown.

Airline economics make the comparison sharper. African airlines earned a net profit of US$1.30 per passenger in 2025, against US$7.90 worldwide, and AFRAA expects their net margin to be 0.2% in 2026. The average international departure charge in 2024, US$68, is about 52 times that profit per passenger.

2026 makes the squeeze worse. IATA's revised outlook puts the average jet fuel price at US$152 a barrel in 2026, 69% above about US$90 in 2025, and AFRAA says fuel can exceed 40% of operating costs in some African markets. Where both hold and fuel is unhedged, operating costs rise by up to about 28% (Heirstone analysis: 40% of costs rising 69%). With costs rising that fast, a tax cut this year is more likely to keep existing seats flying than to add new ones.

52x

Africa's average international departure charge against African airlines' net profit per passenger (Heirstone analysis)

2.4x

rise in the average African arrival tax, 2021 to 2024

42

African countries taxing transfer passengers in 2024, against 35 in 2022

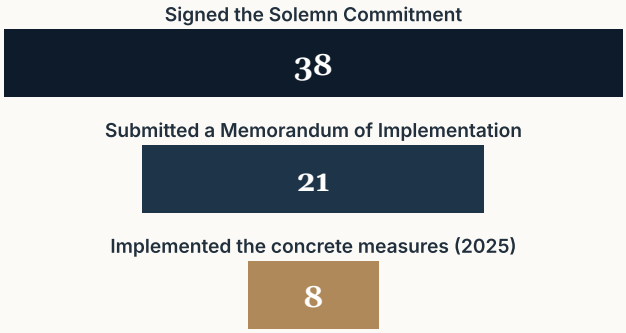
TRAFFIC RIGHTS

Africa launched a single air transport market in 2018; by 2025, eight countries had put its measures in place

EXHIBIT 15

Single African Air Transport Market: 38 signatories, 8 implementers

Number of states at each stage, 2025 to 2026



Source: AFRAA, Liberalization page (2026). **Heirstone analysis:** 55% of signatories have submitted a memorandum, 21% have implemented.

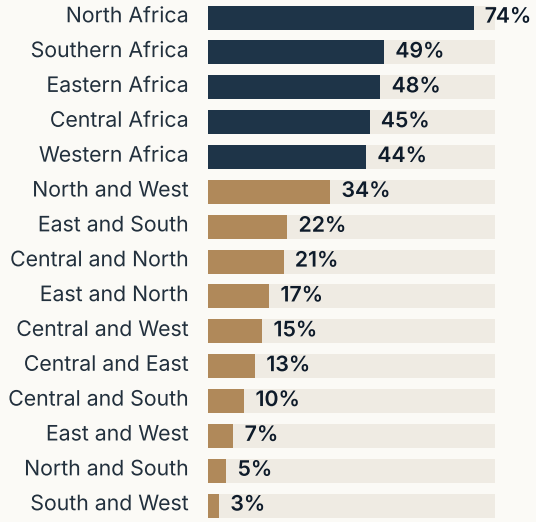
The Single African Air Transport Market, launched in January 2018 to speed up the Yamoussoukro Decision's liberalisation of flying between African states, now has 38 signatories. Twenty-one have submitted a memorandum of implementation and eight had put the concrete measures in place by 2025, according to AFRAA.

Fifth-freedom rights, which let an airline carry passengers between two foreign countries, made up 23% of intra-African capacity in August 2026. The remaining 77% was flown by airlines to or from their own country.

EXHIBIT 16

Direct links between Africa's regions are thin: 3% between Southern and Western Africa

AFRAA direct-flight connectivity rate within regions (navy) and between them (gold), %, second half of 2025



Source: AFRAA, Routes and Connectivity Report H2 2025 (July 2026), OAG data. AFRAA does not state whether rates are city-pair or country-pair based.

Within North Africa, AFRAA rates direct connectivity at 74%; between Southern and Western Africa it is 3%. A two-country holiday that joins the Cape with West Africa, or Morocco with East Africa, usually means a connection through Addis Ababa, Nairobi, Johannesburg or a Gulf hub.

AFRICA'S BUSIEST ROUTES, SECOND HALF OF 2025

SEGMENT	FIVE BUSIEST ROUTES (PASSENGERS WHERE PUBLISHED)	TOP 100 ROUTES, PASSENGERS	WHAT THEY CARRY
Intra-African	Tripoli-Tunis; Harare-Johannesburg; Mogadishu-Nairobi; Algiers-Tunis; Entebbe-Nairobi	4.08m	Business, family and trade corridors
Intercontinental	Algiers-Paris CDG (556,000); Algiers-Paris Orly; Paris Orly-Tunis; Paris Orly-Marrakech; Paris Orly-Réunion	9.30m	Four of five link North Africa with Paris
Domestic	Cape Town-Johannesburg (1.99m); Durban-Johannesburg (1.39m)	13.44m	South Africa's trunk routes lead the continent

Source: AFRAA, Routes and Connectivity Report H2 2025 (July 2026), OAG Traffic Analyser data. The characterisation of each segment is Heirstone analysis.

Intra-African flying is the smallest segment: its top 100 routes carried 30% as many passengers as the top 100 domestic routes and 44% as many as the top 100 intercontinental ones (Heirstone analysis). None of its five busiest routes links two leisure destinations.

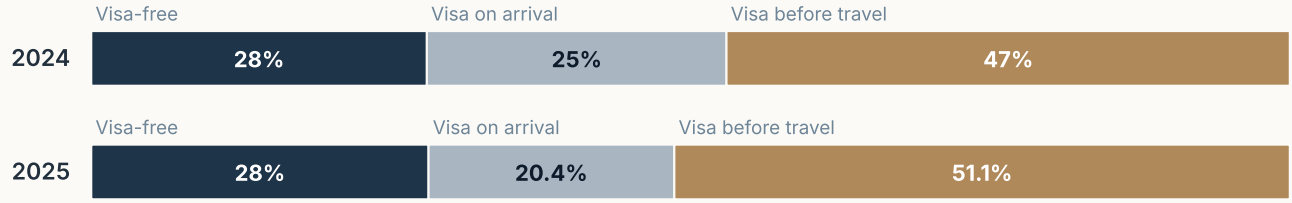
VISAS

Africans needed a visa in advance for a larger share of African destinations in 2025, though e-visas had spread to 31 countries, from 9 in 2016

EXHIBIT 17

Visa on arrival gave way to visas before travel in 2025

Share of intra-African travel scenarios (one nationality to one country) by entry requirement, %

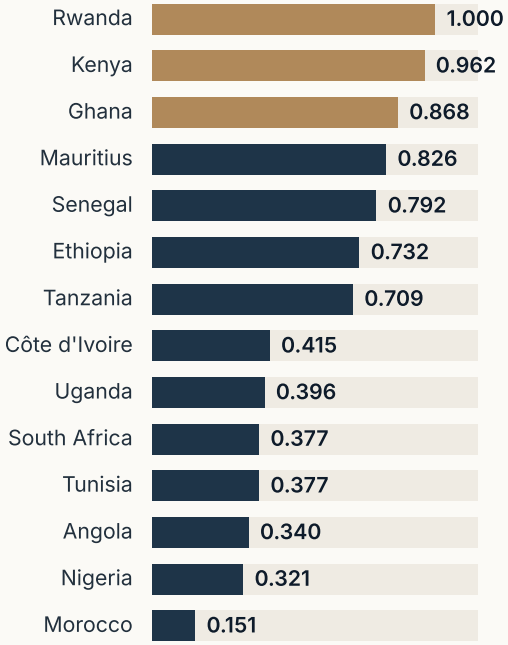


Source: AfDB and African Union, Africa Visa Openness Report 2025. Published shares for 2025 sum to 99.5% because of rounding.

EXHIBIT 18

Rwanda, Kenya and Ghana score highest of the countries shown for openness to African travellers

Africa Visa Openness Index score 2025 (1 = visa-free for all Africans), selected countries



Source: AfDB and African Union, Africa Visa Openness Index 2025, country scores and ranks.

In 2025, 51.1% of intra-African travel scenarios required a visa before travel, up from 47% in 2024, as Guinea-Bissau, Mauritania, Nigeria and Somalia moved from visa on arrival to visas issued in advance. Visa-free scenarios held at 28%, up from 20% in 2016. E-visas spread to 31 countries, from 9 in 2016, which eases the process where a visa is still required. Only The Gambia and Rwanda admit all Africans without one.

The index measures openness to African travellers only, so it does not capture how Morocco and Egypt, with about 19 to 20 million arrivals each in 2025, admit their main source markets. Egypt admits EU, UK and US citizens to its Red Sea resorts for 15 days without a visa and offers e-visas and visas on arrival to many other nationalities. The Maghreb union scores 0.166, the lowest of Africa′s regional economic communities, while ECOWAS offers full visa-free reciprocity.

Rules can change quickly. Kenya introduced an electronic travel authorisation in 2024 and has since exempted African citizens from it, except those of Libya and Somalia, according to the AfDB and African Union.

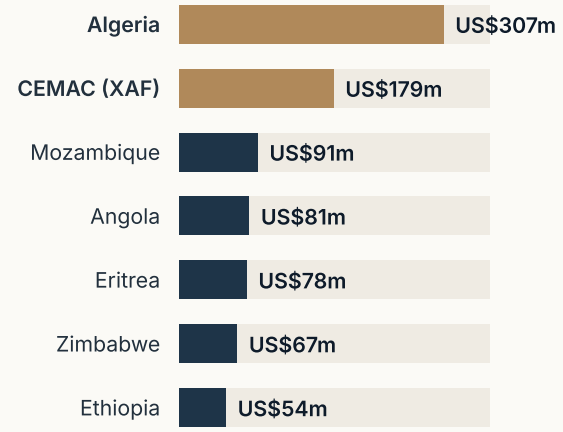
BLOCKED FUNDS

Seven African jurisdictions held US$857m of airline revenue that could not leave the country

EXHIBIT 19

Algeria held the world's largest stock of blocked airline funds in October 2025

Airline revenue that could not be repatriated, US$m, end-October 2025, with global rank



Source: AFRAA, Blocked Funds paper (May 2026), citing IATA. **Heirstone analysis:** sum of the seven, US$857m. CEMAC: Cameroon, Central African Republic, Chad, Congo, Equatorial Guinea and Gabon.

Airlines sell tickets in local currency and must convert and repatriate the proceeds. In October 2025 ten countries held 89% of the world's blocked airline funds, and seven of them were African, according to AFRAA citing IATA. Algeria held the largest stock in the world, US$307m, and the six-country CEMAC currency zone the second largest, US$179m. The seven African balances add up to US$857m, the net profit African airlines would earn on about 660 million passengers at their 2025 margin of US$1.30 each.

Cash that cannot leave the country raises the cost of serving it, in the same way a tax does. The tariffs do not move together: Algeria has one of Africa's lowest departure charges, US$9.80, and the world's largest blocked balance.

The stakes are large relative to these sums. IATA estimates that aviation supports US$75bn of GDP and 8.1 million jobs in Africa, and that opening 12 key markets to each other would add 155,000 jobs and US$1.3bn of GDP a year. These are IATA's estimates; we have not tested them.

FIVE TARIFFS ON ARRIVALS

INSTRUMENT	SET BY	EVIDENCE IN THIS REPORT	WHAT A TOURISM-LED POLICY WOULD AIM FOR
Departure charges	Treasuries and airport authorities	US$1.30 (Libya) to US$297.70 (Gabon); average US$68 (2024)	At or below the US$30 to 34 averages of Europe and the Middle East
Arrival and transfer taxes	Treasuries and airport authorities	Arrival average US$34.10, from US$14.10 in 2021; transfer US$34.40 in 42 countries	No tax on passengers changing aircraft
Visas	Interior and foreign ministries	51.1% of intra-African travel scenarios need a visa before travel	Visa-free entry or a low-cost electronic authorisation for main markets
Traffic rights	Transport ministries and aviation authorities	SAATM: 38 signatories, 8 implementers; fifth freedom 23% of intra-African capacity	Open rights for any airline that adds seats
Blocked funds	Central banks	US$857m in seven African jurisdictions (Oct 2025)	Airline revenue repatriated as it is earned

Sources: as Exhibits 13 to 19. Policy aims are Heirstone recommendations.

> *Visa fees and blocked balances raise the cost of an arrival as surely as a departure tax does, but they never show on the ticket.*

CHAPTER 5

05 The Heirstone Air Access Scorecard

We rated 20 African countries on five levers that decide whether a seat reaches a destination at a price travellers will pay: what the state charges, how open the border is, whether a low-cost airline is based at the gateway, how far the main airport reaches and whether the gateway has room. Ratings use published data and fixed thresholds (page 21).

Each country is also assigned to one of four access models, which decide which lever comes first.

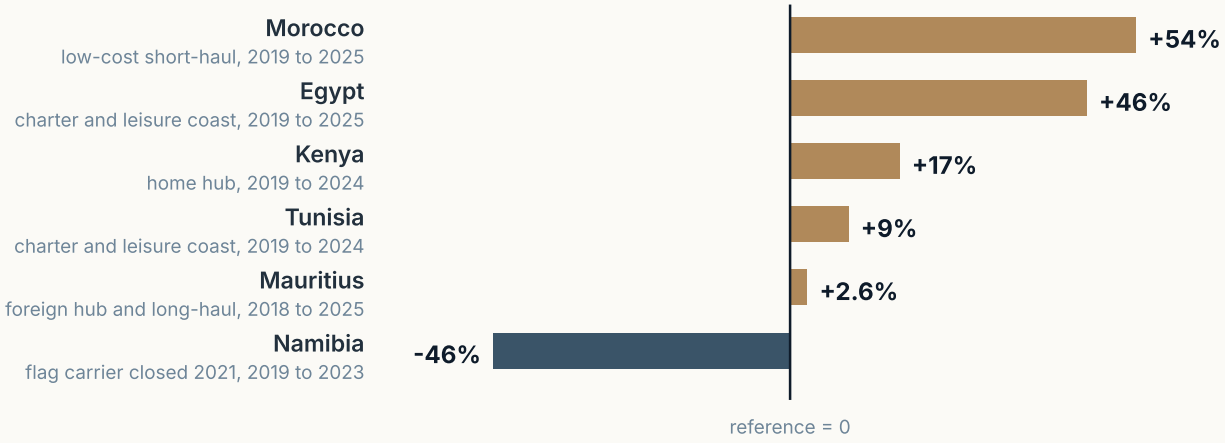
FOUR ACCESS MODELS

Low-cost short-haul Morocco; Tunisia in part	European low-cost airlines fly point to point into several airports, often from local bases.	**First lever:** Bases, slots and terminal space
Charter and leisure coast Egypt's Red Sea; Djerba; Sal (Cabo Verde)	Tour operators and leisure airlines contract seats for the season.	**First lever:** Seat incentives and a wider spread of source markets
Home hub Ethiopia, Kenya, Rwanda; Johannesburg	A national network airline brings seats with it, most of them for transfer passengers.	**First lever:** Turning transfer passengers into visitors; visas
Foreign hub and long-haul Mauritius, Seychelles, Zanzibar, Cape Town	Gulf, Istanbul and European airlines decide where to send their aircraft.	**First lever:** Route development and airline business cases

EXHIBIT 20

Morocco and Egypt, fed mainly by low-cost and charter airlines, have grown fastest since before the pandemic

Change in international arrivals from the latest pre-pandemic year to the latest year published, %, with access model



Source: Ministry of Tourism (Morocco) via Hespress and Daba Finance; World Bank WDI (UN Tourism data) for Egypt and Kenya in 2019; Egypt Independent; Tourism Research Institute (Kenya); Kapitalis (Tunisia); Statistics Mauritius; Ministry of Environment, Forestry and Tourism (Namibia). **Heirstone analysis.** Periods differ by country.

THE SCORECARD

Twenty countries, five levers

EXHIBIT 21

No country rates open on all five levers, and the first lever differs from country to country

Heirstone Air Access Scorecard, 2026: rating and value for each lever. Airport codes: RAK Marrakech, HRG Hurghada, ABV Abuja, ADD Addis Ababa, ZNZ Zanzibar, CPT Cape Town

● Open ● Partial ● Constrained

COUNTRY	ARRIVALS, M	YEAR	PRICE, US$	VISA (AVOI)	LOW-COST BASE	HUB REACH	GATEWAY LOAD	BLOCKED, US$M	MODEL	FIRST LEVER
NORTH AFRICA										
Morocco	19.8	2025	● 25	● 0.151	● base	● 26	● RAK 113%		L	Terminal space at Marrakech
Egypt	19.0	2025	n/p	● 0.109	● fly in	● 18	● HRG 88%		K, H	Low-cost base on the Red Sea
Tunisia	10.3	2024	● 15	● 0.377	● fly in	● 11	n/p		K	EU aviation agreement
Algeria	n/p		● 10	n/p	n/p	n/p	n/p	● 307	n/c	Repatriation of airline funds
WEST AND CENTRAL AFRICA										
Senegal	n/p		● 123	● 0.792	● fly in	● 10	n/p		H	Departure charges
Côte d'Ivoire	n/p		n/p	● 0.415	● none	● 18	n/p		H	Visas; reach beyond West Africa
Ghana	1.31	2025	● 112	● 0.868	● none	● 14	n/p		n/c	Departure charges
Nigeria	n/p		● 180	● 0.321	● none	● 16	● ABV 39%		n/c	Departure charges; visas
Gabon	n/p		● 298	n/p	n/p	n/p	n/p	● 179*	n/c	Charges; repatriation
EAST AFRICA										
Kenya	2.39	2024	n/p	● 0.962	● domestic	● 22	n/p		H	Turning transfers into visits
Ethiopia	n/p		n/p	● 0.732	● none	● 38	● ADD 60%	● 54	H	Turning transfers into visits
Rwanda	n/p		n/p	● 1.000	● none	● 12	n/p		H	More seats; Bugesera timing
Tanzania	2.1	2024	n/p	● 0.709	n/p	● 13	n/p		F, K	Terminal space at Zanzibar
SOUTHERN AFRICA										
South Africa	10.5	2025	● 29	● 0.377	● base	● 23	● CPT 87%s		F, H	Visas; wider route development
Namibia	0.86	2023	n/p	n/p	n/p	n/p	n/p		F	Long-haul seats
Botswana	n/p		● 19	n/p	n/p	n/p	n/p		n/c	Long-haul access to Maun
Angola	n/p		● 28	● 0.340	n/p	● 11	n/p	● 81	H	Repatriation; visas
INDIAN OCEAN										
Mauritius	1.44	2025	n/p	● 0.826	n/p	● 5	n/p		F	Seats from new markets
Seychelles	0.40	2025	n/p	n/p	● none	n/p	n/p		F	More airlines and markets

Source: Heirstone Air Access Scorecard 2026, built from AFRAA (taxes 2024; blocked funds Oct 2025, citing IATA), AfDB and AU (AVOI 2025), FlightConnections schedules (2026), France Aviation Civile Services (2025 passengers), airport operators and the press for design capacity, Wesgro, national statistics offices and tourism ministries. n/p: not published in the sources we could verify. * CEMAC currency zone total. Arrivals definitions differ by country; Morocco includes Moroccans resident abroad.

Price: international departure charges (AFRAA, Sep 2024). Open up to US$34 (Middle East average); partial US$34 to 68; constrained above US$68 (Africa average).

Visa: Africa Visa Openness Index 2025, which measures openness to Africans only. Open 0.70 or more; partial 0.35 to 0.70; constrained below 0.35. The index does not cover visitors from outside Africa: Egypt admits EU, UK and US visitors to its Red Sea resorts for 15 days without a visa.

Low-cost base: open where a low-cost airline is based at the main leisure gateway (or, where there is none, the capital) with an international network; partial where low-cost airlines fly in without a base, or the local one flies mainly domestic routes; constrained where we found none.

Hub reach: African capitals (of 53) served non-stop from the main airport, 2026. Open 20 or more; partial 10 to 19; constrained below 10.

Gateway load: 2025 airport traffic against the design capacity of the main gateway's terminals; ABV against its new terminal only, which overstates use. CPT (s) is a different measure: international passengers against published seats, rated on the same thresholds. Open below 80%; partial 80 to 100%; constrained above 100%.

Blocked funds: shown where a jurisdiction was in IATA's global top ten in October 2025; all such cases rated constrained.

Model: L low-cost short-haul; K charter and leisure coast; H home hub; F foreign hub and long-haul; n/c not classified.

READING THE SCORECARD

Four things the scorecard shows

No country is open on every lever, and the first lever differs.

Morocco, Tunisia and South Africa price departures below the Middle East average, but Morocco's leisure gateway is full and South Africa's visa score is middling. Ghana, Rwanda and Senegal are open to Africans and expensive or thin on seats.

Low-cost bases are rare south of the Sahara.

Outside Morocco and South Africa we found no low-cost airline based at a main leisure gateway with an international network. Morocco's 19.8 million arrivals rest on that model.

Hub reach and tourism scale do not coincide.

Addis Ababa reaches 38 of 53 African capitals non-stop on our count of published schedules, more than any other airport we compared, yet Ethiopia received 0.8 million international arrivals in 2019, the latest year in the World Bank series, against 2.0 million for Kenya.

Conversion varies widely.

Visitor arrivals per one-way airport passenger were about 1.31 in Morocco (five airports, 2025), 0.70 in Egypt (four), 0.68 at Zanzibar, 0.60 at Accra, 0.58 in South Africa (three) and 0.37 at Nairobi JKIA (2024). Diaspora, transit and land arrivals distort every figure (Heirstone analysis).

A TEST FOR RESORT AND HOTEL PROJECTS

Access before assets: five questions to answer before buying land

A resort is only as good as the seats into its nearest gateway. These are the questions we would put to any tourism project in Africa that depends on air arrivals, whether advising the landowner, the developer, the hotel investor or the lender. The thresholds come from the evidence in this report.

1 **Which access model feeds the site, and how many?**

Count the airlines and source markets that fly into the gateway. When one large market stops flying, arrivals can fall sharply within a year. A site fed by two models, such as low-cost and charter, is more resilient than one fed by a single foreign hub.

2 **Will the gateway have room in the opening year?**

Compare forecast traffic with terminal design capacity. Marrakech was at 113% in 2025. Above about 85%, ask who is funding the next terminal and when; works at Bugesera, contracted in 2016, were paused in 2019 and opening is now expected in 2028.

3 **What does the state add to the fare?**

Add departure, arrival and transfer charges for a return trip and compare them with competing destinations. A departure charge above the Africa average of US$68 is a warning sign for price-sensitive leisure markets.

4 **Can the target guest get in easily?**

Check the entry rule and its price for the top three source markets. An electronic authorisation and a consular visa put very different costs and delays on a family holiday.

5 **Who will pay to bring the seats, and how will success be measured?**

Identify the route-development budget or seat incentive behind the plan, as in Cape Town or Egypt, and agree a target for visitors per inbound seat. Western Cape achieves about 0.76.



CHAPTER 6

06 North Africa and Sub-Saharan Africa

NORTH AFRICA

The continent's best-connected region now finds its limits in terminals more than in traffic rights

North Africa generated 42.4% of African airline traffic in the first quarter of 2026, has the lowest departure charges of any sub-region, at US$25 on average, and the densest internal network: AFRAA rates its direct connectivity at 74 to 90%, depending on the period. Four of the five busiest intercontinental routes touching Africa in the second half of 2025 linked North Africa with Paris.

Morocco. Marrakech passed its design capacity in 2024 and ran at 113% of it in 2025. Casablanca, Royal Air Maroc's hub, reaches 113 destinations non-stop, 100 of them on the national airline. The 2030 target of 26 million tourists is 31% above 2025 (Heirstone analysis); the leisure gateways, more than the hub, will decide whether it is met.

Egypt. Sharm el-Sheikh was the fastest-growing of Africa's 26 largest airports in 2025, Marsa Alam the third and Hurghada the fourth. Arrivals reached a record of about 19 million in 2025, and the government targets 30 million a year. Charter and leisure airlines supply most seats; Air Cairo, a self-described hybrid airline, is making Hurghada a key hub and plans more than 130 aircraft by 2034, and a based low-cost operation, backed as charters were in 2016, would add a second access model. Egypt's airports can handle 66.2 million passengers a year, and the target for 2026/27 is 72.2 million.

Tunisia. Tunisia levies US$15 per departure and received 10.3 million visitors in 2024, yet at Tunis the network is run mainly by Tunisair and Nouvelair, with Transavia the only low-cost airline among the leading carriers. Tunisair's passengers fell from 3.8 million in 2018 to 2.5 million in 2025. Low charges have not brought a low-cost base; an open aviation agreement with the EU is the most direct lever.

Algeria and Libya. Libya charges US$1.30 per departure and Algeria US$9.80, both among the four lowest in Africa. Algeria holds the world's largest stock of blocked airline funds, so repatriation comes first. Within the Maghreb, visa-free reciprocity fell from 70% to 60% in 2025.

42.4%
of African airline traffic generated in North Africa (Q1 2026)

US$25
average international departure charge in North Africa (2024)

23.3m
passengers at Hurghada, Sharm el-Sheikh and Marsa Alam in 2025

0.166
Maghreb union visa openness score, the lowest of Africa's regional communities

SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA: ANGLOPHONE MARKETS

East Africa has the hubs and the open borders, while Nigeria and Ghana charge among the most to fly out

South Africa. Cape Town shows what route development can do with foreign airlines, and on our estimate its international seats fill well above Africa′s average load factor. South Africa received 10.5 million foreign tourists in 2025, up from 8.9 million in 2024, and charges US$28.50 per international departure. Its weaker lever is entry: a visa openness score of 0.377, with an electronic travel authorisation piloted only for G20 participants since October 2025. Johannesburg reaches 23 African capitals non-stop, and Safair, a South African low-cost airline, flies to 12 destinations from Johannesburg and 10 from Cape Town.

Kenya. Kenya replaced visas with an electronic travel authorisation in 2024 and has since exempted African citizens other than those of Libya and Somalia; it ranks third on visa openness. Visitors rose 14.6% to 2.39 million in 2024 and earnings 19.8% to KSh452.2bn, about US$3.35bn at the 2024 average rate. Nairobi is a transfer hub: visitor arrivals through JKIA equalled about 0.37 of its one-way passengers (Heirstone analysis). The KES 154.2bn JKIA contract, about US$1.19bn, signed in June 2026 after a concession proposal was cancelled in November 2024, adds capacity; converting transfers into stays is the larger prize.

Ethiopia and Rwanda. Ethiopian Airlines flies to 136 of the 140 destinations served non-stop from Addis Ababa, which reaches 38 African capitals. Ethiopia requires a visa in advance from only five African countries. The gap is conversion: Ethiopia received 0.8 million international arrivals in 2019, the latest year in the World Bank series. Rwanda admits all Africans without a visa and scores 1.000. RwandAir flies 18 of Kigali′s 26 non-stop destinations, and the new Bugesera airport is now expected in 2028.

Tanzania and Zanzibar. Zanzibar received a record 917,167 international arrivals in 2025, and its airport handled 2.69 million passengers, up 13.9%. Terminal space is the next constraint: the airport authority expects to finish a second terminal, for 1.4 million passengers a year, in 2026.

Nigeria and Ghana. Nigeria charges US$180 per departure, moved to visas before travel for Africans in 2025 and has seen the naira lose about 79% of its dollar value between 2019 and 2024. Lagos still grew 13.1% in 2025. Ghana received 1.31 million visitors in 2025, 82.6% of them through Accra, with a US$111.50 departure charge. In both, price is the first lever.

38

African capitals reached non-stop from Addis Ababa, against 23 from Johannesburg and 22 from Nairobi

0.37

visitor arrivals through Nairobi JKIA per one-way airport passenger, 2024 (Heirstone analysis)

US$1.19bn

JKIA design-and-build contract, KES 154.2bn at the 2025 average rate

917,167

international arrivals in Zanzibar in 2025, a record

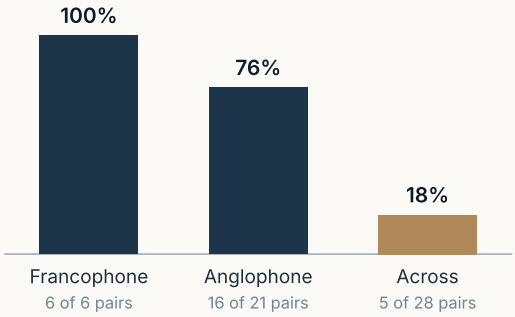
SUB-SAHARAN AFRICA: FRANCOPHONE MARKETS AND THE ISLANDS

Six of Africa's ten highest departure charges are levied in French-speaking states, and few flights link them to anglophone Africa

EXHIBIT 22

Few non-stop flights cross Africa's language line

City pairs with a scheduled non-stop service, 2026, among four francophone and seven anglophone cities



Source: Heirstone count of FlightConnections schedules, 2026. Francophone: Abidjan, Dakar, Casablanca, Tunis; anglophone: Johannesburg, Cape Town, Nairobi, Lagos, Accra, Dar es Salaam, Entebbe. **Heirstone analysis.**

Six of the ten highest international departure charges in Africa are levied in French-speaking states: Gabon, Djibouti, Niger, Benin, Senegal and DR Congo. Central Africa averages US$107 per departure and West Africa US$109. Libreville adds the continent's highest arrival tax, US$127.80, and the CEMAC currency zone held US$179m of blocked airline funds in October 2025, the second-largest balance in the world.

Francophone cities connect well with each other and with Casablanca, which reaches 15 francophone capitals non-stop. Across the language line, links are scarce: of 28 pairs between four francophone and seven anglophone cities, 5 have a non-stop flight, and Dakar and Tunis have none to any of the seven. A tour operator selling a circuit that joins West Africa with East or Southern Africa meets that gap first.

Côte d'Ivoire. Abidjan handled 2.52 million passengers in 2025, up 0.9%, and reaches 18 African capitals non-stop. Air Côte d'Ivoire flies to 20 of Abidjan's 34 non-stop destinations. Abidjan's arrival charge is low, at US$7.90, but the country scores 0.415 on visa openness. Visas and reach beyond West Africa are the first levers.

Senegal. Dakar's Blaise Diagne airport, budgeted at EUR 566m in 2011, opened in December 2017; traffic grew 0.5% in 2025, to 2.94 million. Senegal charges US$122.60 per international departure, 4.9 times Morocco, although it scores 0.792 on visa openness and belongs to ECOWAS, the first regional community to reach full visa-free reciprocity. Air Senegal flies to 11 of Dakar's 35 non-stop destinations. Charges are the lever.

Central Africa and the islands. Gabon's charges, Libreville's arrival tax and the CEMAC blocked balance make Central Africa the costliest region to serve; clearing funds and cutting charges come before marketing. Mauritius, whose largest market is France, and Seychelles both depend on foreign hub carriers, and Mauritius reaches five African capitals non-stop. Cabo Verde's Sal airport handled 1.59 million passengers in 2025, up 18.8%.

6 of 10

highest international departure charges in Africa are levied in French-speaking states (2024)

15

francophone capitals reached non-stop from Casablanca

4.9x

Senegal's international departure charge against Morocco's

CHAPTER 7

What to do

The evidence in this report puts most of the levers on air access with governments, airports and the investors who decide where to build, more than with airline fleet plans. These are the measures we would put to each group.

FOR

Tourism authorities and destination agencies

- Set up a route-development unit with marketing money and airline business cases. Cape Town's added 33 international routes in ten years.
- Publish visitors per inbound international seat for each gateway, every year. The Western Cape's is about 0.76.
- Spread seats across source markets and airlines, and keep a seat-incentive budget ready: Egypt's US$30-a-seat programme of 2016 helped arrivals recover after two large markets suspended flights.
- Treat the national airline as one supplier of seats among several.

FOR

Finance ministries, aviation authorities and immigration

- Benchmark departure charges against the US$30 to 34 levied in Europe and the Middle East; West and Central Africa average over US$100.
- Stop taxing passengers who change aircraft: 42 countries do, at US$34.40 on average.
- Implement the SAATM measures already signed; 8 of 38 signatories have.
- Replace visas for main markets with low-cost electronic authorisations, and clear blocked airline balances before marketing new routes.

FOR

Airports and concession holders

- Add terminal space first where leisure traffic exceeds design, as at Marrakech (113% in 2025).
- Publish route incentive schemes with discounts tied to seats delivered, open to any airline.
- Report seats as well as passengers each month, by airline and market.
- Plan mega-hubs with realistic dates and budgets: Bugesera, contracted in 2016, is now due in 2028 at 2.4 times its first budget, with a larger design.

FOR

Developers, hotel investors and lenders

- Apply the access-before-assets test before buying land or committing debt.
- Underwrite on seats into the named gateway rather than on national arrivals.
- Prefer sites fed by more than one access model, and stress-test a one-year fall of 40% in arrivals if a large source market stops flying, together with the path to recovery.
- Treat a new airport's published opening date as a best case.

How Heirstone works on air access and destinations

We help tourism authorities, landowners, developers and investors decide what to build and where: tourism demand and air-access studies by gateway and source market, destination strategy, highest-and-best-use and site selection, feasibility and business models (DCF, IRR, NPV and Monte Carlo testing), masterplanning and phasing, and benchmarking of the kind in this report.

Get in touch

info@heirstoneconsulting.com
heirstoneconsulting.com

NOTES, SOURCES AND DEFINITIONS

Notes

Definitions

ASK: available seat kilometres, a measure of capacity. **RPK:** revenue passenger kilometres, a measure of traffic. **Load factor:** RPK as a share of ASK. **Seats filled** (Cape Town): two-way international passengers divided by two-way international seats. **Departure charge:** the sum of taxes, fees and charges on a departing ticket as compiled by AFRAA from IATA data. **AVOI:** AfDB and African Union Africa Visa Openness Index, which scores openness to African nationals only. **SAATM:** Single African Air Transport Market. **Fifth freedom:** the right to carry passengers between two foreign countries. **Leisure gateway:** an airport whose traffic is mainly resort or holiday travel, on Heirstone classification.

Method

Figures are as published, in the currency and period stated. Local-currency amounts are converted at World Bank official annual average rates for the year shown (KES 129.3 per US$ in 2025; KES 134.8 and NGN 1,479.0 in 2024; NGN 306.9 in 2019); amounts spread over many years are not converted. The Heirstone Air Access Case Book records 7 dated events in 5 countries with arrivals and a capacity proxy; its ratios divide percentage changes and are indicative, not causal. The Scorecard rates five levers against the thresholds on page 21. Where sources conflict, as on African airlines' intercontinental share, we show each figure as published. Terminal capacity use compares annual passengers with published design capacity; Cape Town's seats-filled ratio is a different measure and is indicative. No annual seat series by country is public; seat figures are used only where published.

Use of this report

This report is published for general information. It is not investment, legal or valuation advice and should not be relied on as such. Images are illustrative.

1 FLOWN BY OTHERS

IATA, 2025 passenger demand (29 Jan 2026) and August 2026 demand (30 Sep 2026); AFRAA, Air Transport Reports Q4 2025 (May 2026) and Q1 2026 (Aug 2026), performance update (15 Sep 2026), Liberalization page (2026) and press release (Sep 2026); OAG webinar (6 Aug 2026); UN Tourism via AFRAA Blocked Funds paper (2026); Wesgro (2025, 2026).

2 THE PINCH POINTS

France Aviation Civile Services, Air Transport Data Trend Bulletin (2026); ATTA citing OAG (2026); Wesgro; Egypt Independent (2026); AfDB (2025); Egypt Today (2025); Ahram Online via Travel News (2026); China Daily (2023); Al Jazeera (2019); CNN (2023); The New Times (2019, 2024); The Star (2026); Daily Nation citing KAA (2026); OCCRP (2024); APS via Seneweb (2011); AIBD SA; Al Arabiya citing Ahram Online (2014); Bladi.net (2016); Quartz (2019); Vanguard citing FAAN (2018); Zanzibar Airports Authority (2026); African Union SAATM page; World Bank official exchange rates (PA.NUS.FCRF).

3 WHAT MOVED ARRIVALS

Wesgro, Cape Town Air Access releases and brochure (2025, 2026); World Bank, World Development Indicators, ST.INT.ARVL (UN Tourism data); Ministry of Tourism (Morocco) via Hespress (2023), MAP (2025) and Daba Finance (2026); TravelDailyNews (2025); Egypt Today (2024); Economy Middle East; Egypt Independent (2016, 2022, 2026); UK Government (2015, 2019); The National (2015); Associated Press and Egypt Today (2021); Air Cairo press releases (2026); Statistics Mauritius (2018, 2025, 2026); National Bureau of Statistics Seychelles (2023 to 2026); Tourism Research Institute, Kenya (2025); Kapitalis (2025); African Manager (2019); Ecofin Agency (2026); aeroTELEGRAPH (2021); Ministry of Environment, Forestry and Tourism (Namibia), Tourist Statistical Report 2023.

4 TARIFFS ON ARRIVALS

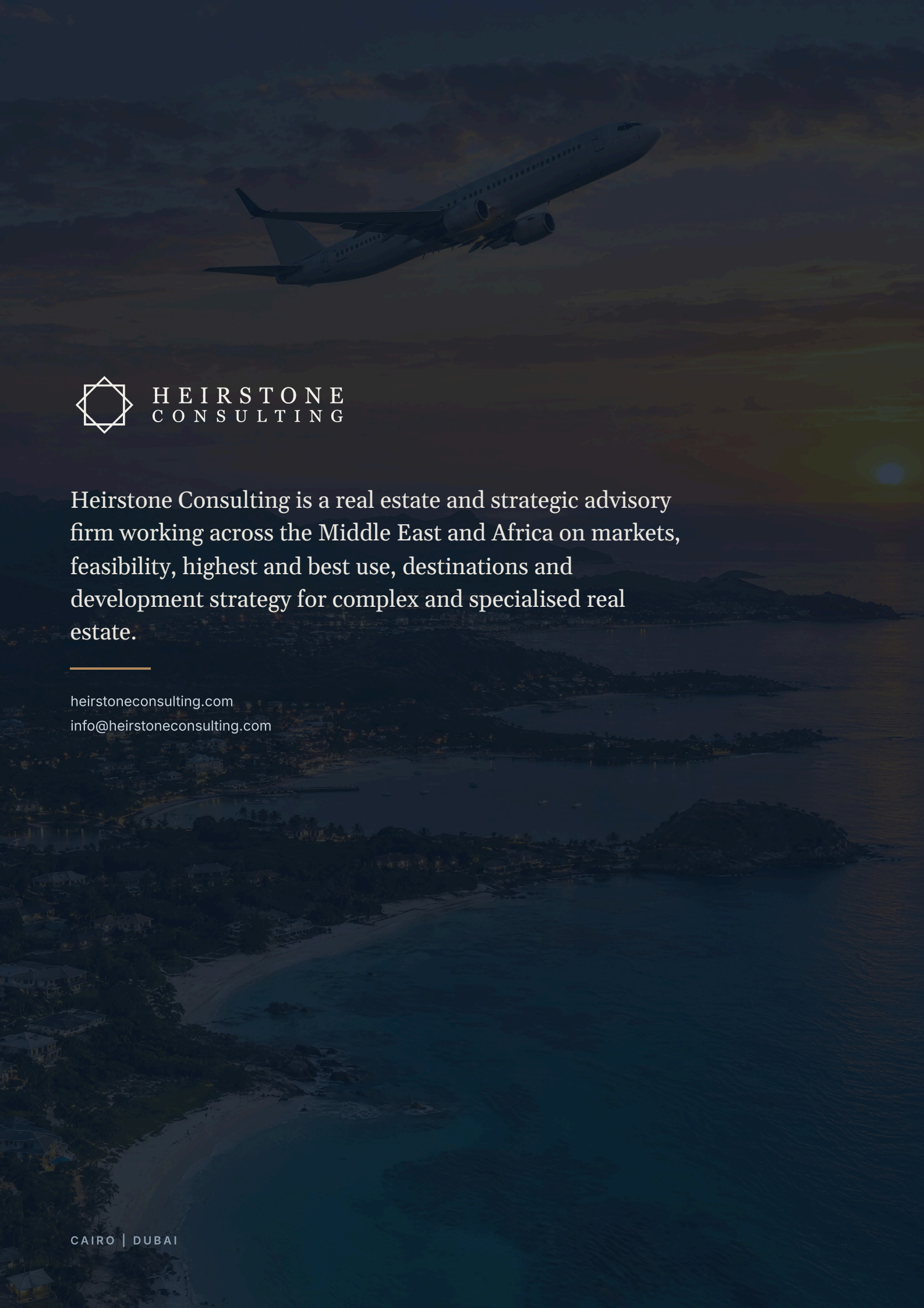
AFRAA, Taxes, Fees and Charges Study 2024 (June 2025), Blocked Funds paper (May 2026), Routes and Connectivity Report H2 2025 (July 2026), fuel procurement release (Sep 2026); AfDB and African Union, Africa Visa Openness Report and Index 2025; IATA fuel outlook via AFRAA; OAG webinar (Aug 2026); AFRAA, Liberalization page (2026); IATA, SAATM page (2026); Consulate General of Egypt in London, Visas (2024); Ministry of Interior (Egypt), e-Visa portal (2026).

5 SCORECARD

As chapters 1 to 4, with FlightConnections schedules (2026) compiled in the Heirstone connectivity dataset; Ghana Tourism Authority (2025 report); Ghana Civil Aviation Authority (2025 statistics).

6 REGIONS

As above, with Statistics South Africa, International Tourism 2025 (2026); TanzaniaInvest citing the International Visitors' Exit Survey 2024 (2025); The Citizen citing the Office of the Chief Government Statistician, Zanzibar (2026); Hürriyet Daily News (2025); FlightConnections schedules (2026); World Bank exchange rates.



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Heirstone Consulting is a real estate and strategic advisory firm working across the Middle East and Africa on markets, feasibility, highest and best use, destinations and development strategy for complex and specialised real estate.

heirstoneconsulting.com
info@heirstoneconsulting.com

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